Perioperative Patient Care — Full Notes

Extended study notes covering the pre-operative, intra-operative, and post-operative phases of patient care.

Pre-operative phase

- Confirm patient identity, consent, and procedure against documentation
- Review allergies, current medications, and relevant lab/imaging results
- Ensure fasting guidelines have been followed appropriately
- Remove jewellery, dentures, and prosthetics per local policy
- Mark the surgical site where applicable, involving the patient if possible
- Address patient anxiety — a calm, clear explanation reduces perioperative stress measurably

Intra-operative phase

- Maintain the sterile field throughout the procedure
- Monitor patient positioning continuously, not just at setup
- Track swab, sharp, and instrument counts at defined points in the procedure
- Support communication between surgeon, anaesthetist, and nursing/scrub team
- Document key events, times, and any deviations from the planned procedure

Post-operative phase — immediate recovery

- Handover from theatre to recovery includes procedure summary, findings, and concerns
- Airway, breathing, and circulation monitored closely as anaesthesia wears off
- Pain assessed and managed according to the patient's individual response
- Wound and dressing checked for bleeding or early signs of complication

Post-operative phase — ongoing ward care

- Early mobilisation encouraged where clinically appropriate — reduces complications like DVT
- Wound care and dressing changes follow the surgical team's specific instructions
- Patient and family educated on warning signs to report after discharge

Common post-operative complications to watch for

- Haemorrhage — internal or at the wound site
- Infection — surgical site or systemic
- Deep vein thrombosis / pulmonary embolism
- Atelectasis and other respiratory complications
- Delayed wound healing, especially in patients with risk factors

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